

Ceremonies

The most important Christian ceremonies are the sacred rites known as sacraments. The Roman Catholic and Orthodox Churches recognize seven sacraments: baptism (the rite of entry into the Church); confirmation (a further initiation ceremony); the Eucharist (Mass); penance (turning to God after sin); extreme unction (preparation for death); ordination (becoming a priest); and marriage. The Protestant Churches recognize baptism and the Eucharist.

Baptism

This ritual is an act of ceremonial cleansing before becoming a member of the Church. In some cases, holy water is splashed on the head of the infant. In other cases, an adult entering the Church is totally immersed in water.



Marriage

Christians believe that marriage symbolizes the relationship of Christ with his Church. It marks the beginning of a new family and a new generation.

Eucharist

At his last supper with his disciples, Christ identified the bread and wine as his body and blood. Christians remember this at the Eucharist (or Mass), at which a priest consecrates bread and wine and distributes it among the worshippers.

A priest blesses the wine in a chalice.

Sixteenth-century silver chalice



An Amish couple in Pennsylvania travel in a horse-drawn carriage.



Amish

The Amish are a Protestant sect founded in the 17th century. Its followers live separately from the rest of society and believe that salvation can only be reached within the community. In the United States, Amish communities follow a simple lifestyle with strict rules. They reject modern technology and wear traditional dress, such as waistcoats and hats and bonnets and capes.

Festivals

The most important Christian festival is Easter, when believers commemorate Christ's crucifixion and resurrection. The celebration of Christ's birth, Christmas, is an important festival. Ancient pagan festivals merged with Christian festivals, so that old fertility rites are linked with Easter and winter festivals with Christmas.



In the Middle Ages, saints' relics were kept in reliquaries.

Saints' days

Christians who have lived outstanding lives, or who were killed for their beliefs, are revered as saints. Each saint has his or her own special day, and these are often marked with processions, celebrations, and church services. Festivals on saints' days are particularly popular in Catholic countries.

Reliquary of St Eustace, an early Roman Christian martyr



The Adoration of the Magi by Botticelli (1444–1510)

Easter

The celebration of Easter can involve many moods, from the solemn prayers of Good Friday, when the crucifixion is remembered, to joy at the resurrection three days later. A spring festival, Easter is a time when new life is celebrated. Christ's resurrection is reflected in the new growth of plants and crops, and is celebrated in the giving of Easter eggs.

Christmas

Christ's nativity (birth) is traditionally celebrated in December. The Christmas story tells of his birth in a stable in Bethlehem. The many Christmas customs include giving presents, decorating trees, lighting candles, singing special hymns (or carols), and eating elaborate meals.

This nativity painting shows the worship of the Magi, the three Wise Men who came bearing gifts.

Christians carry a statue to symbolize Christ carrying the cross.



An Easter procession in Granada, Spain

Bible

The sacred text of the Christian religion is the Bible. Its first part is the Old Testament, a group of books inherited from the Jews, among whom Christianity originally grew up. Second comes the New Testament, which is made up of books dealing with the early history of Christianity. The New Testament includes the four Gospels, the Acts and Epistles (giving details of the spread of Christianity), and the Book of Revelation (containing prophecies for the future).

The Dead Sea Scrolls



Gospels

The first four books of the New Testament are called the Gospels, from a word meaning "good news". They tell the story of the life of Christ. Three of the four Gospels (those of Matthew, Mark, and Luke) are very similar and are known as the Synoptic Gospels. John's gospel is quite different from the others, and its author may not have known the other three texts.

Dead Sea Scrolls

These scrolls of parchment were discovered in caves near Qumran on the Dead Sea in the 1940s and 1950s. They contain writings which include texts of parts of the Old Testament in versions earlier than any previously discovered. They were hidden in AD 68.

St Paul

Originally opposed to Christianity, Paul (d. AD 64) converted when he had a vision of Christ. He began to preach Christianity and spread the faith on four arduous missionary journeys through Greece and Asia Minor. His role was central to the early development of the Church. He wrote several of the New Testament books in the form of letters to the Christian communities he visited.



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